

THE FAMILIAR

Team Game Design Document | Project 3

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Design basis. The kickoff selects a single creature pretending to be someone the player knows. This document develops that selected concept into a playable prototype due October 16, 2026. The alternate zombie-disguise and five-face concepts are not part of the selected design.

Draft status. The working title, concrete progression, rule thresholds, art direction, and scope details below are proposed additions. Section author assignments reflect relevant system ownership and require team confirmation; they do not claim the members wrote this draft. The kickoff's text renders K'von's name inconsistently; confirm its spelling before submission.

Missing source. No art sheet is included in the kickoff. Section 6 is a proposed art sheet; the team has authorized the proposed direction below. Field coverage against any separate course template remains unverified.

1. Core loop

Proposed section author(s): Megan Pearce

Observe a familiar person's routine, investigate its unsettling deviations, and use the evidence to unlock an escape route while hiding from the mimic as it becomes more aggressive.

2. The systems

Proposed section author(s): Each member for their owned system

Familiar Behavior System | Megan Pearce

Owens: trust_level, behavior_stage, current_action, is_acting_normal.

Does: Performs recognizable routines, movement, and short dialogue; changes from normal to subtly wrong to openly uncanny as evidence accumulates. trust_level describes the apparent relationship, not an invisible player morality score. This system supplies the familiar performance; the Monster System supplies pursuit decisions.

Observation / Suspicion System | Michael Nearn

Owens: suspicion_level, clues_found, noticed_anomaly.

Does: Registers clues only when the player inspects them, records evidence once, and advances suspicion through unaware, doubtful, and certain stages. Looking at an anomaly enables investigation; inspecting it confirms the clue.

2. The systems (continued)

Proposed section author(s): Each member for their owned system

Escape / Environment System | Jadin Hutchinson

Owns: door_state, player_location, escape_progress, is_hidden.

Does: Handles the small house layout, locks, hiding interactions, and the escape objective. For rule 3 it also owns the proposed player_is_still value. The prototype progresses from finding a basement key to unlocking the basement route to reaching the exit. It validates movement and hiding, and resolves the final escape trigger.

Mimic / Monster System | K'von Gates

Owns: monster_state, monster_location, disguise_state, target.

Does: Runs one creature through disguised, stalking, chasing, searching, and lost-target states; handles the basement interception and capture scare. It makes threat decisions from the other systems' published state, without changing their evidence or door values.

3. The seams

Proposed section author(s): Michael Nearn and K'von Gates

Each value has one owning writer. Readers consume values or events and make the decisions below. All four systems participate.

A. Familiar Behavior → Observation / Suspicion

Writes: current_action, behavior_stage, is_acting_normal.

Reads: Observation / Suspicion.

Decision: Whether an observed action is an inspectable anomaly. On player inspection, it records a unique clue and raises suspicion; merely being nearby does not grant evidence.

B. Observation / Suspicion → Familiar Behavior

Writes: suspicion_level.

Reads: Familiar Behavior.

Decision: Which performance stage to present: ordinary routine when unaware, repeated or mistimed gestures when doubtful, stiff posture and an unnatural smile when certain.

C. Observation / Suspicion → Mimic / Monster

Writes: suspicion_level.

Reads: Mimic / Monster.

Decision: Whether to remain disguised, start stalking, or allow pursuit after the player is certain. This implements rule 1.

D. Escape / Environment → Mimic / Monster

Writes: escape_progress, door_state, player_location, is_hidden, player_is_still.

Reads: Mimic / Monster.

Decision: Whether to intercept the basement route, chase a visible player, or switch from pursuit to search and then lose the target. These values implement rules 2 and 3.

4. The familiar thing

Proposed section author(s): Megan Pearce

What is familiar: A trusted companion in a domestic setting, introduced through an ordinary greeting, a repeated household routine, and recognizable gestures. The precise relationship can remain unnamed so the prototype needs no elaborate backstory.

What makes it turn: The same performance begins to repeat at the wrong time, pauses too long, and ends in a stiff smile. Confirmed clues advance behavior_stage through the suspicion seam. The player realizes the familiar person is a shell being imitated by a creature.

How play changes: Initially the player approaches and observes the companion. After finding evidence, the player keeps distance, checks routes before opening doors, and uses cover instead of treating the companion as a source of safety. The transition is taught through visible behavior and consequences.

5. The monster

Proposed section author(s): K'von Gates

One mimic uses the three rules established in the kickoff. The state conditions below make them implementable; thresholds and timings are prototype proposals to tune in playtesting.

Rule 1. Recognition increases aggression

Reads: suspicion_level and player_location.

Response: Unaware: maintain disguise. Doubtful: stalk. Certain: pursue when the player is visible and reachable.

How the player learns: The first confirmed clue is followed by a clear change in distance and posture; the next stage produces more persistent following. Repeat this relationship so it can be inferred rather than explained only by a meter.

Rule 2. An escape attempt provokes interception

Reads: escape_progress, basement_door_state, and player_location.

Response: When the basement route becomes ready, move to the interception position before the door-opening event. Opening the door triggers the reveal, then pursuit. If the creature has not arrived, delay the reveal rather than visibly teleporting it.

How the player learns: Footsteps toward the basement and a shadow under the door warn that the escape route attracts the creature; the opening reveal confirms the pattern.

Rule 3. Concealment plus stillness breaks tracking

Reads: is_hidden, player_is_still, and player_location.

Response: Entering a hiding place out of sight changes pursuit to search. Remaining still for a proposed three seconds clears the target. Hiding in direct view does not erase knowledge of the player; moving interrupts the stillness timer.

How the player learns: Footsteps slow, pause, and recede after successful concealment. Moving too early brings them back, providing feedback on both required conditions.

5. The monster (continued)

Proposed section author(s): K'von Gates

Predicted scariest moment

Where: The basement doorway, after the player has gathered enough evidence and unlocked the apparent way out.

Moment: The player opens the door expecting relief. The familiar figure is waiting just beyond it, arms at its sides, motionless, smiling. It holds the pose for a brief readable beat, then pursues the player back toward a nearby hiding place.

Rules in play: Rule 2 causes the interception; rule 1 makes the now-aware player's encounter aggressive; rule 3 provides a learnable way to survive the chase. The hiding route must be accessible before the reveal, and capture must result from failed escape or concealment rather than an unavoidable cutscene.

6. Art direction

Proposed section author(s): Megan Pearce and Jadin Hutchinson

Proposed team art sheet. The team requested this proposed direction. These fields establish a consistent direction; a separate course template was not supplied. Reference screenshots are omitted as requested.

Style and mood

Visual style: Stylized low-poly 3D with simple silhouettes and restrained textures.

Mood: Domestic comfort gradually becomes uncanny; tension comes from repetition, posture, and proximity.

Setting: One compact house with a living area, connecting hall, hiding alcove or closet, and basement exit route.

Palette and lighting

Palette: Warm cream (#D7C9A8), muted wood brown (#735744), charcoal (#252A2C), and sickly desaturated green (#6E7B65). Use a restrained dark red (#793F3F) for danger feedback.

Lighting: Warm illumination in the opening room, dim cooler hallway light, and a basement doorway framed by darkness. Keep navigable surfaces and hiding entrances readable; darkness should obscure the threat without making movement guesswork.

Characters, props, and animation

Player: First-person viewpoint; no full player model required.

Mimic: One familiar human silhouette and one rig. Uncanny variation comes from timing, a stiff smile, and posture rather than another enemy model.

Props: Reuse a small set of doors, furniture, a key, and clue objects.

Animation: Normal idle and walk, mistimed gesture, stiff reveal pose, chase, and capture. Prefer a few readable states over many bespoke clips.

6. Art direction (continued)

Proposed section author(s): Megan Pearce and Jadin Hutchinson

Camera, interface, and sound

Camera: First-person with a stable view; frame the basement reveal through the doorway. No forced 180-degree spin is required.

Interface: Minimal interaction prompts, a short evidence readout, and clear restart/win screens. Use readable text and do not encode danger through color alone.

Sound: Quiet household ambience; distinct footsteps for approach, searching, and retreat; a short door/reveal cue. Audible warnings support the monster rules, with captions or equivalent visible cues for critical information.

Asset consistency: Keep scale, material roughness, polygon density, and lighting treatment consistent across reused assets.

7. Scope

Proposed section author(s): Jadin Hutchinson, with all system owners

In: one complete playable prototype

One small house, one first-person player, and one mimic; three inspectable clues that advance suspicion; three familiar behavior stages; one key and basement escape route; one reusable hiding interaction; the three monster rules; one doorway reveal; clear win, capture, and restart states. Target a short session of approximately five minutes, subject to playtesting.

Completion criteria: A new player can observe the normal routine, confirm clues, recognize escalating pursuit, unlock the basement route, survive by hiding still, and reach the exit. Each seam must produce the documented decision, and a restart must reset all owned state. Playtesting checks that warnings and hiding feedback let players explain the rules after a run.

Delivery plan | Due October 16, 2026

October 7-9: Build the house blackout, movement, one familiar routine, clue inspection, and shared state interfaces. Each owner connects their system to at least one seam.

October 10-12: Complete the key/door objective, stalking and chase, hiding/stillness rule, basement interception, and win/capture/restart flow. Have a full playable build by October 12.

October 13-14: Playtest whether players infer all three rules; fix blocked routes, unreliable hiding, and state-reset bugs. Apply consistent low-poly assets, lighting, and audio cues.

October 15: Freeze features, run a complete escape and capture/restart check, and prepare the final PDF and build.

October 16: Complete uploads and repository commit by the course deadline; verify the exact submission time. If the October 12 milestone slips, reduce clue count to two and use static normal/uncanny poses while retaining all three monster rules.

Three cuts

1. Multiple monsters and skin-disguise gameplay. Cut the mutated-zombie roster, stalking/killing loop, and wearable skins. The kickoff explicitly favors one AI creature for a two-week build.

2. Five-face sensory counter system. Cut face-specific actions, multiple lives, and a helper that gives incorrect instructions. These would create a competing core loop and additional teaching requirements.

3. Flashlight battery and blackout QTE system. Cut battery simulation, randomized flicker, and rescue button sequences. Use authored lighting and footsteps to support the chosen mimic rules.